

One October Holiday, Two Names: Columbus Day and Indigenous Peoples' Day

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On October 12, 2026, people across the United States will observe a holiday that goes by two different names. Some will celebrate Columbus Day, while others will mark **Indigenous Peoples' Day**.

Columbus Day honors Christopher Columbus, an Italian explorer who arrived in the Americas on October 12, 1492. But his role in history has long been debated. Critics say his arrival led to the **colonization** and mistreatment of Native Americans.

Historians also point out that Columbus did not "discover" the Americas. **Indigenous** peoples had already been living there for thousands of years. He was not even the first European to reach North America. A **Norse** explorer named Leif Erikson reached the continent around A.D. 1000, almost 500 years before Columbus.

Because of these concerns, some states chose not to celebrate Columbus Day. Hawaii renamed the holiday Discoverers' Day in 1971 to honor its **Polynesian** founders. South Dakota began calling it Native American Day in 1990.

In 1977, a group of Native American leaders suggested the name "**Indigenous Peoples' Day**" to honor those who were mistreated by early settlers. In 1992, Berkeley, California, became the first city to make the change. Since then, more than 100 cities and several states have **adopted Indigenous Peoples' Day**. In 2021, President Joe Biden officially recognized the holiday and asked Americans to celebrate it on the second Monday of October, along with Columbus Day.

Not everyone agrees that a new name is needed. For many Italian Americans, Columbus Day is an important part of Italian **Heritage** Month, which is observed every October. They say the holiday celebrates Italian culture, not Columbus himself. Some have suggested calling it "Italian **Heritage** Day."

The debate shows that history can be complicated. No matter the name, the holiday is a time to think about the past.

Word Treasure

colonization -- When people from one country take control of another land and settle there.

Indigenous -- Describing the first people known to live in a place.

Norse -- Describing people from old Scandinavia, such as the Vikings.

Polynesian -- Describing people from a large group of Pacific Ocean islands.

Heritage -- The traditions, history and culture passed down in a family or group.

adopted -- Officially chose to use or follow something.

Background you need

Columbus Day was created to remember Christopher Columbus's voyage across the Atlantic Ocean in 1492.

Indigenous peoples are the first peoples of a place, such as the many Native American nations who lived across the Americas long before Europeans arrived.

Columbus's voyages opened the way for European countries to set up colonies in the Americas, which changed Native American lives in many harmful ways.

Today, communities debate how one holiday can honor both the people who were already here and immigrant groups such as Italian Americans.

Break it down

LEAD: The October 12 holiday is called Columbus Day by some and Indigenous Peoples' Day by others

BACKGROUND: Columbus arrived in the Americas on October 12, 1492, where Indigenous peoples already lived

+ - **DEBATE:** Critics link his arrival to colonization and mistreatment of Native Americans

CHANGES: Hawaii in 1971, South Dakota in 1990, Berkeley in 1992, then more than 100 cities and several states

KEY EVENT: In 2021, President Joe Biden officially recognized Indigenous Peoples' Day

OTHER VIEW: Many Italian Americans see Columbus Day as a celebration of Italian culture

OPEN QUESTION: How should one holiday honor different histories?

Why it matters

The debate shows how communities rethink history and decide whom to honor. It also shows that people can look at the same past in very different ways.

Test what you remember

1. When did Columbus arrive in the Americas?

- ☐ (A) Around A.D. 1000
- ☐ (B) October 12, 2026
- ☐ (C) In 1971
- ☐ (D) October 12, 1492

2. Who reached North America around A.D. 1000?

- ☐ (A) Joe Biden
- ☐ (B) Hawaii's Polynesian founders
- ☐ (C) Leif Erikson
- ☐ (D) Christopher Columbus

3. What did Hawaii rename the holiday in 1971?

- ☐ (A) Discoverers' Day
- ☐ (B) Explorers' Day
- ☐ (C) Native American Day
- ☐ (D) Italian Heritage Day

4. Which city was the first to switch to Indigenous Peoples' Day?

- ☐ (A) Honolulu, Hawaii
- ☐ (B) Rapid City, South Dakota
- ☐ (C) Berkeley, California
- ☐ (D) New York City

5. What did President Joe Biden do in 2021?

- ☐ (A) Canceled Columbus Day
- ☐ (B) Officially recognized Indigenous Peoples' Day
- ☐ (C) Renamed Hawaii's holiday
- ☐ (D) Created Italian Heritage Month

6. Why do many Italian Americans support keeping Columbus Day?

- ☐ (A) They want the holiday moved to summer
- ☐ (B) They say Columbus was the first European in North America
- ☐ (C) They say it celebrates Italian culture
- ☐ (D) They say it honors Leif Erikson

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: A 4: C 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

- 1. Critics of Columbus Day:** Argue that Columbus's arrival led to the colonization and mistreatment of Native Americans.
- 2. Historians:** Point out that Columbus did not discover the Americas and was not the first European to reach North America.
- 3. Native American leaders:** Suggested Indigenous Peoples' Day to honor those mistreated by early settlers.
- 4. Italian Americans:** Say Columbus Day celebrates Italian culture, and some suggest calling it Italian Heritage Day.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):